

# Shoulder Recovery Plan

A printed reference for taking care of him after surgery. Keep it on the fridge.

**Surgery:** May 11, 2026

**Surgeon:** Dr. Silver

**Hospital:** NYU Langone Orthopedic

## What happened

Dad fell on March 3 and tore the tendons in his shoulder. These are called the **rotator cuff**. They are what let you lift your arm.

On **May 11**, Dr. Silver fixed the tear. Through small cuts in the shoulder, he sewed the torn tendons back to the bone. He used tiny anchors to hold them in place. He also added a patch on top, like a bandage on the inside, to make the repair stronger.

The surgery went well. No problems. Dad came home the same day.

## What to expect

- The shoulder needs **4 to 6 weeks** in the sling. No exceptions.
- Then physical therapy starts and lasts months.
- **Full recovery: 6 to 9 months**. Be patient.
- The biggest risk is moving the arm too soon. If the repair fails, he needs another surgery.

### The 4 most important rules

1. **Sling stays on**. Day and night. Even sleeping. Only off for showers.
2. **No lifting with that arm**. Nothing heavier than a coffee cup.
3. **Pain meds with food**. Always. Or he gets sick.
4. **Ice the shoulder**. 15-20 min, many times a day for week 1.

## A normal day, roughly

### Morning

- Help him out of bed slowly
- Bathroom, breakfast
- Morning meds (with food)
- Pain meds if needed
- Ice 15-20 min
- Check fingers look pink

### Afternoon

- Lunch (then pain meds OK)
- Short walk if up for it
- Ice 15-20 min
- Rest in recliner
- Help with anything two-handed

### Evening

- Dinner with evening meds
- Ice one more time
- Pain meds if needed
- Brush teeth, wash up

### Bedtime

- **Pain meds BEFORE sleep**
- Sling stays ON
- Pillows around the arm
- Phone within reach

## The sling: how to put it on

1. Sit him down. Arm in his lap or on a pillow.
2. Slip his elbow into the bend of the sling.
3. Reach the long strap up and over the OTHER shoulder.
4. Pull the Velcro through the front rings, stick it down.
5. Check: elbow at 90°, arm across belly, only wrist and hand showing.

## Ice / cooling sleeve

- **15-20 min on, then off**. 3-5 times a day in week 1.
- If he has the cooling sleeve, follow its directions. Better than ice packs.
- For ice packs, wrap in a thin towel. Never on bare skin.
- Best times: morning, before bed, before pain meds.

## Showering

- **First 5 days: no showers**. Sponge baths only.
- **Day 5 (May 16)**: Take dressing off, rinse cuts gently, cover with daily Band-Aids.
- **After day 5**: Sling off in shower. Arm hangs straight down at his side. You wash him. Sling back on right after.
- No baths, pools, hot tubs until the doctor says OK.

## Things he absolutely cannot do

- Lift more than a coffee cup with that arm
- Reach overhead
- Sleep without the sling
- Drive while taking oxycodone
- Drink alcohol while on pain meds
- Take Advil or aspirin without asking the doctor

## Week-by-week checklist

Use a pen. The boxes are real. The web version of this guide also has these checkboxes and they save automatically in your browser.

| WEEK 1 The hard week                                                                                                                    | May 11 – 17 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>First night: pain meds BEFORE bed</b><br>Numbing block wears off in the night. Don't wait for pain.         |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Pick up oxycodone &amp; Tylenol</b><br>NYU pharmacy, 301 East 17th St. Mon–Fri, 9 AM – 10 PM.               |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Set pillows around his arm at night</b><br>So he can't roll onto it. Recliner is even better for night 1-2. |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Check fingers every 2 hours on day 1</b><br>Should be pink. If pale, blue, or numb past 48hr → call doctor. |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Ice many times a day</b><br>15-20 min on, off. Use cooling sleeve if you have one.                          |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Eat something before pain meds</b><br>Even crackers. Empty stomach + pain pills = vomiting.                 |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Keep dressing dry. NO showers for 5 days.</b><br>Sponge baths only.                                         |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Day 5 (May 16): take off the dressing</b><br>Rinse cuts gently with soap & water. Cover with Band-Aids.     |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Push fluids and fiber</b><br>Pain pills cause constipation. Prune juice, water, Colace.                     |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Help him with everything</b><br>Lay out clothes. Cut up food. He can't use that arm.                        |             |

| WEEK 2 First check-up                                                                                                                    | May 18 – 24 |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>May 19, 10:30 AM: Post-op visit</b><br>Stitches come out. With Svetlana, PA. Bay Ridge. Arrive 15 min early. |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Start cutting back oxycodone</b><br>Try 1 pill instead of 2. Use Tylenol in between. Less every day.         |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Showers OK now</b><br>Sling off in shower. Arm hangs straight down. You wash him.                            |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Sling back on right after towel-off</b><br>Don't let him "test" the arm.                                     |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Ice less often, but still daily</b><br>A few times a day instead of all day.                                 |             |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Fresh Band-Aid on incisions daily</b><br>Until doctor says they're healed.                                   |             |

| WEEKS 3-4 Settling in                                                                                                                  | May 25 – Jun 7 |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>May 28, 11:15 AM: Dr. Dekhovich + scan</b><br>West Brighton. Two appointments back-to-back.                |                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>June 4: Cardiac cath with Dr. Kamran</b><br>For his heart, not the shoulder. Confirm time with cardiology. |                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Try to be off oxycodone</b><br>Just Tylenol now. Call doctor if pain is still bad.                         |                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>SLING STILL ON. All the time.</b><br>This is when people start cheating. Don't let him.                    |                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Move his hand and wrist daily</b><br>Open/close fist, wiggle fingers. Just hand and wrist, nothing higher. |                |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Watch his mood</b><br>By now he's bored, frustrated. Normal. Get him out for walks.                        |                |

| WEEKS 5-6 Sling comes off                                                                                                               | Jun 8 – 21 |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Schedule next visit with Dr. Silver</b><br>If they didn't already give one. Office: 929-455-2000.           |            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Ask the doctor when to STOP the sling</b><br>Don't take it off on your own. Wait for the surgeon to say so. |            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Get the PT referral</b><br>Ask office for the script and a PT clinic near him.                              |            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Book first PT appointment</b><br>2-3 times a week to start.                                                 |            |

| MONTHS 2-3 Physical therapy                                                                                         | Jul – Aug |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>PT 2-3x/week</b><br>Therapist moves the arm at first, then teaches him exercises.       |           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Home exercises EVERY DAY</b><br>PT only works if he does them at home. Daily reminder.  |           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>July 16, 11 AM: GI follow-up Dr. Su</b><br>Stomach doctor. Manhattan. Not the shoulder. |           |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Still no heavy lifting</b><br>No suitcases, groceries, or grandkids on that arm.        |           |

| MONTHS 4-9 Back to normal                                                                                                    | Sep onward |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------|
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Strength training added to PT</b><br>Slowly building muscles back up.                            |            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Most normal activities OK</b><br>Driving, light cooking, dressing himself. Doctor will say when. |            |
| <input type="checkbox"/> <b>Full recovery: 6-9 months out</b><br>Heavy lifting and full strength take this long. Don't rush. |            |

# All the *medications*

Two new pain pills to start. Some old ones to stop. Everything else stays the same.

**STRONG · USE WITH CARE**

**Oxycodone**

also called Roxicodone · 5 mg pill

**2 pills every 6 hours, only if needed**

Drop down to 1 pill as pain gets better. Never more than 8 pills (40 mg) in one day.

**Always with food.**

Bottle has 30 pills.

**MILD · SAFER**

**Tylenol**

also called Acetaminophen · 500 mg pill

**2 pills every 6 hours, only if needed**

Use BETWEEN oxycodone doses for steady coverage. Bottle has 60 pills.

**The pain plan: alternate them every 3 hours**

Pain pills wear off after 4-6 hours. If you take them **together**, there are stretches with no coverage. If you **alternate** them every 3 hours, something is always working. **Always with food.**

|             |            |                            |              |            |                        |
|-------------|------------|----------------------------|--------------|------------|------------------------|
| <b>8 AM</b> | <b>OXY</b> | 2 oxycodone with breakfast | <b>11 AM</b> | <b>TYL</b> | 2 Tylenol with a snack |
| <b>2 PM</b> | <b>OXY</b> | 2 oxycodone with lunch     | <b>5 PM</b>  | <b>TYL</b> | 2 Tylenol with a snack |
| <b>8 PM</b> | <b>OXY</b> | 2 oxycodone with dinner    | <b>11 PM</b> | <b>TYL</b> | 2 Tylenol before bed   |

Skip a dose if he doesn't need it. As pain gets better, drop the oxycodone first. Keep Tylenol if he still needs it.

**The first night rule**

The numbing block from surgery wears off in the middle of the night. Take pain medication BEFORE bed on the first night. With food. Don't skip this. He'll thank you in the morning.

## Pills to STOP and KEEP

### STOP taking (paused for surgery)

- Aspirin 81 mg (Bayer)
- Voltaren 75 mg (diclofenac)
- Gralise 300 mg (gabapentin)
- Crestor 10 mg (rosuvastatin)
- Prilosec 40 mg (omeprazole)
- Flonase nasal spray
- Kenalog ointment
- Alpha Lipoic Acid, Vitamin B

Aspirin and Voltaren make you bleed more. Ask Dr. Silver or Dr. Beker when he can restart these.

### KEEP taking as normal

- Metformin 500 mg — once daily with meals (diabetes)
- Hyzaar 100/12.5 mg (losartan-HCTZ) — once daily (BP)
- Toprol XL 25 mg (metoprolol) — once daily (heart/BP)
- Pletal 100 mg (cilostazol) — twice daily (circulation)
- Blood sugar checks — same as always

**NEVER mix oxycodone with these**

- Alcohol. Even one drink. It can stop his breathing.
- Sleeping pills (Ambien, etc.)
- Anti-anxiety pills (Xanax, Ativan, Klonopin)
- Other pain pills from any source

When to *worry*

Call 911 / Go to the ER NOW

- Chest pain or trouble breathing
- Fingers turn pale, blue, or purple
- Arm stays totally numb after 48 hours
- Heavy bleeding from the bandage
- Confused, very weak, or dizzy
- Hasn't peed in 8+ hours
- Can't wake him up or breathing is very slow

Call Dr. Silver: 929-455-2000

- Fever over 101°F (38.3°C)
- Chills
- Cuts get red, hot, swollen, or have pus
- Strange liquid from the cuts
- Pain that meds aren't helping at all
- Throwing up that won't stop
- Pain or swelling in his calf (could be a blood clot)

Things that look bad but are NORMAL

- **Bruising down the arm.** Blood drains with gravity. Can spread to his hand. Goes away in 1-2 weeks.
- **Some swelling.** Ice helps.
- **Tingling / pins & needles** as block wears off. This is the cue to take pain meds.
- **Constipation.** Normal from pain pills. Fluids, fiber, laxative if needed.
- **Trouble sleeping.** Recliner helps.
- **Feeling down or grumpy** after a few days. Surgery is hard on the spirit.

If you can't reach the office and you're worried, take him to urgent care or the ER. Tell them he had shoulder surgery on May 11 with Dr. Silver at NYU.

Upcoming *appointments*

|                                      |                                                                                                                                           |                                     |                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>MAY</b><br><b>19</b><br>10:30 AM  | <b>Stitches come out</b><br>With Svetlana, PA<br>NYU Bay Ridge · 6740 Fourth Ave, 4th Fl<br>📞 929-455-2000<br><b>Arrive 15 min early.</b> | <b>MAY</b><br><b>28</b><br>11:15 AM | <b>Follow-up + leg artery scan</b><br>Dr. Dekhovich, then scan at 11:45 AM<br>NYU West Brighton · 2857 W 8th St, Ste 200<br>📞 929-455-3060 |
| <b>JUN</b><br><b>04</b><br>scheduled | <b>Heart procedure (cardiac cath)</b><br>With Dr. Kamran<br>For his heart, not the shoulder.<br>Confirm time with cardiology.             | <b>JUN</b><br><b>29</b><br>11:15 AM | <b>Eye doctor (first visit)</b><br>Dr. Golan<br>NYU Eye Center · 7901 4th Ave, Ste A4<br>📞 718-748-1334                                    |
| <b>JUL</b><br><b>16</b><br>11:00 AM  | <b>Stomach doctor</b><br>Dr. Su<br>NYU Gastroenterology · 150 E 32nd St, Ste 101<br>📞 212-263-3643                                        |                                     |                                                                                                                                            |

Dr. Silver's office will likely add more shoulder visits as he heals. Physical therapy starts around weeks 4-6.

Phone *numbers*

|                                                     |                                                            |                                                 |                                                |
|-----------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------|
| <b>EMERGENCY</b><br><b>911</b>                      | <b>Poison Control (med mistake)</b><br><b>800-222-1222</b> | Dr. Silver's office<br><b>929-455-2000</b>      | NYU Orthopedic Hospital<br><b>888-453-3627</b> |
| Anesthesia (block questions)<br><b>212-598-6085</b> | Anesthesia after hours<br><b>212-263-7300</b>              | NYU Pharmacy (E 17th St)<br><b>212-598-6143</b> | 988 Crisis Line<br><b>988</b>                  |

When you call the doctor's office

Have these ready: **full name · date of birth · MRN (medical record #) · surgery date: May 11, 2026 · surgeon: Dr. Silver.** The MRN is on every piece of paperwork from NYU.